
2.3 Unit 2: Governing the UK

What students
need to learn:

Students must learn all topic areas within this unit. There are no optional topics within Unit 2.

The Constitution

Key concepts	Content explanation
constitution constitutionalism codified/uncodified constitution unitary/federal constitution parliamentary sovereignty pooled sovereignty devolution quasi-federalism elective dictatorship	■ Nature of the constitution — a knowledge and understanding of the features of a constitution and of the benefits of constitutional government, including the differences between codified and uncodified constitutions, and an understanding of the nature, sources and key features of the UK constitution. ■ Sovereignty and the constitution — a knowledge and understanding of debates about the location of sovereignty within the UK constitutional system, particularly in relation to the significance of European Union membership and devolution. ■ Reforming the constitution — a knowledge and understanding of key reforms to the constitution since 1997, such as devolution and Lords reform, and an awareness of their advantages and disadvantages; and an understanding of ongoing debate about constitutional reform, including the possible introduction of a 'written' constitution.

Parliament

Key concepts	Content explanation
Parliament Westminster model representative and responsible government parliamentary government presidential government fusion/separation of powers bicameralism accountability	■ Legislatures and executives — a knowledge and understanding of the different relationships between legislatures and executives in parliamentary and presidential systems of government, and an awareness of the advantages and disadvantages of each. ■ Role of Parliament — a knowledge and understanding of the composition, role and powers of the House of Commons and the House of Lords, and an awareness of the functions of Parliament and how effectively it discharges them, including an awareness of the relationship of Parliament to the European Union and devolved assemblies. (<i>A detailed knowledge of the workings of Parliament is not necessary.</i>) ■ Reforming Parliament — a knowledge and understanding of recent and proposed reforms of Parliament, including an awareness of their implications and alleged benefits or drawbacks.

The Prime Minister and Cabinet

Key concepts	Content explanation
cabinet government core executive prime ministerial government presidentialism political leadership collective responsibility individual responsibility	■ Role of the Prime Minister and Cabinet — a knowledge and understanding of the role of the Prime Minister and Cabinet within the context of the core executive and the conventions of collective and individual responsibility. (<i>Separate questions will not be set on the civil service.</i>) ■ Powers of the Prime Minister — a knowledge and understanding of the sources of prime ministerial power and of key constraints on the Prime Minister, including external factors that affect executive policy making. ■ Prime ministerial leadership — a knowledge and understanding of the leadership style adopted by Prime Ministers and of the changing relationship between Prime Ministers and their parties, cabinet and Parliament, including debates about the presidentialisation of UK politics.

Judges and Civil Liberties

Key concepts	Content explanation
judiciary judicial independence judicial neutrality civil liberty/civil liberties rule of law	■ Role of the judiciary — a knowledge and understanding of the role and significance of the judiciary in promoting rule-based governance. ■ Power and influence of judges — a knowledge and understanding of the relationship between the judiciary and other branches of government, and of the extent to which judges can check the power of the executive and the legislature. ■ Civil liberties and individual rights — a knowledge and understanding of the impact of the courts on the issues of civil liberties and individual rights including the implications of the Human Rights Act and possible reforms such as the introduction of a supreme court and a constitutional bill of rights, and of the relationship between the judiciary, the European courts and EU law.